

STATE REVIEW LEARNINGS:

UNIVERSITY OF CENTRAL ARKANSAS

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: February 19–20, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

UNIVERSITY OF CENTRAL ARKANSAS

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

Overall Performance Level		
MEETS		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
APPROACHING	MEETS	EXCEEDS

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	APPROACHING	BELOW
Recommendations		
Recruiting additional candidates, specifically in subject shortage areas, will support the program's Standard 1 performance moving forward. Additionally, consider what additional supports those candidates may need to increase the 3-year completion rate. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 1.2b, Criteria 1.3a)</i>		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (i.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	The MAT program at UCA has specific plans for continuous improvement in promoting both the number and quality of teacher candidates.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10	-14.1%	BELOW

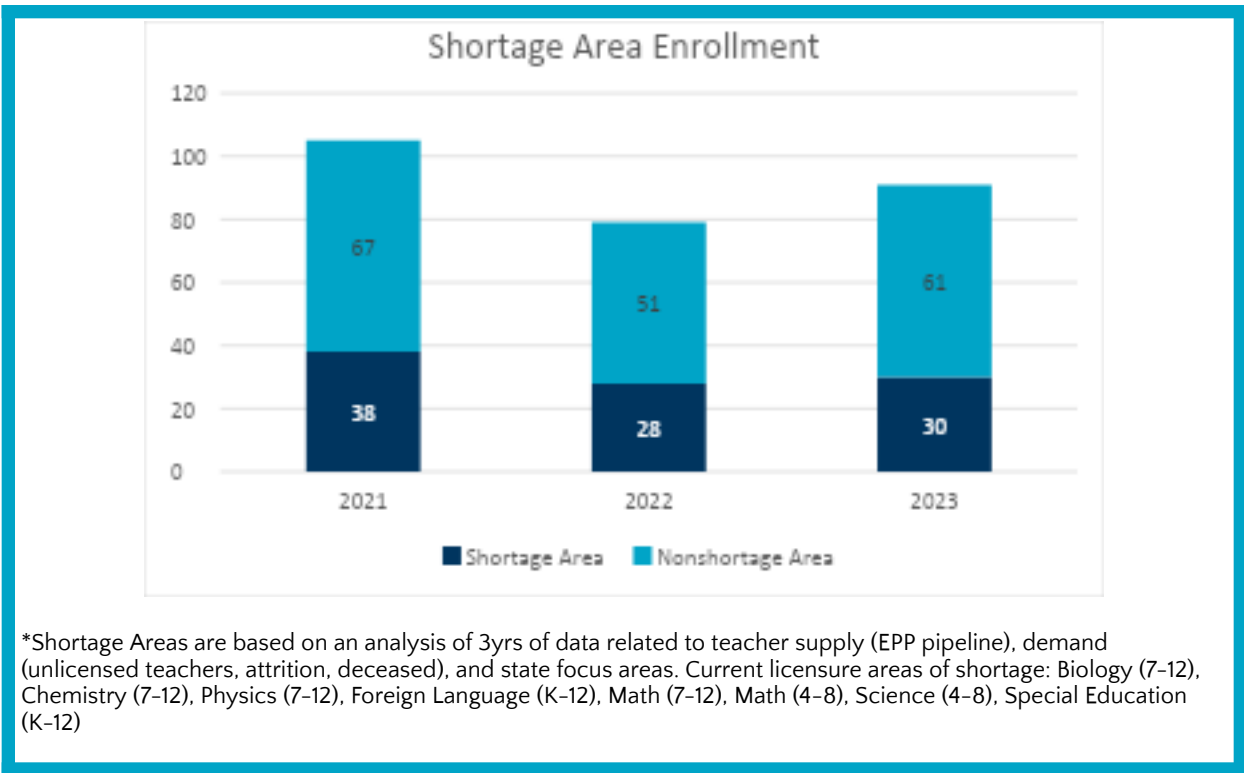
Enrollment

Metric is the percentage growth between blue and green boxes.

Year	Percentage Growth
2018	92
2019	115
2020	119
2021	105
2022	79
2023	91

*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a “Meets” rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an “Exceeds” rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	35%	EXCEEDS



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	74%	61%	BELOW

Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
MEETS	EXCEEDS	MEETS
Recommendations		
The alternative program at the University of Central Arkansas demonstrated they are a strong education program preparing and supporting teacher candidates. UCA regularly surveys course instructors, clinical supervisors, mentor teachers and teacher candidates to better understand what is working well and where to continue to improve. School partnerships, course instructors and clinical supervisors are a strength at UCA, providing candidates with support and feedback. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: - Document a clear and intentional process to fully support graduate students in their internship experience which includes opportunities to expose them to a variety of experiences especially for those candidates already in a teacher of record role. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2a Metric 2</i>) - Document a clear and intentional system to recognize high performing teacher candidates and offer opportunities and feedback that encourage their retention; this may be in collaboration with partner school leaders and/or experienced mentor teachers. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 2.3b Metric 4</i>) - Begin preparing now to meet the state's one-year residency requirement that will apply to spring 2027 completers and beyond. Formalize systems and structures to ensure that the mentor teachers and clinical supervisors working with candidates in the building are experienced, very effective and, by the 2026–2027 school year, have received DESE-recognized coaching training. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b, 2.3c Metric 2</i>)		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based EXCEEDS
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction EXCEEDS Most coursework documentation, where applicable, clearly and intentionally incorporates best practices around content instruction, including HQIM and best practice by using specific language and stating the alignment in syllabi, course matrices, and assessments. Specific examples include content syllabi for Reading Difficulties (MAT 6314) which clearly aligns course outcomes and weekly course topics to the Foundations of Reading (multiple weeks) and HQIM (specifically noted in week 12). The syllabus for Math and Science for Diverse Learners (ELSE 6333) is aligned with HQIM and Arkansas Competencies for Special Education (and other competencies).

Course Instructor focus group participants shared examples of how they help teacher candidates develop an understanding of HQIM. For example, they explore HQIM assessments and bias issues, candidates pull HQIM and deeply critique it and candidates use HQIM to develop performance assessments. Another participant said there is an HQIM training for candidates, they teach from HQIM plans and learn how to annotate an HQIM lesson (to make it their own, with mentor support), and then teach from those annotated lessons (using HQIM materials available to candidates on campus).

In one course observation, Classroom Assessment (MAT 6311), reviewers observed the instructor using academic language throughout the course, modeling the progression of selecting standards, unpacking to create depth of knowledge (Webb's DOK) and learning objectives (both lower and higher levels). In the assignment, HQIM is required, if applicable to the candidate's content area and subject. The syllabus makes explicit how various assignments align to HQIM, and course objectives are aligned with TESS, NMSA, Aspiring TESS, ATS, and ISTE standards.

The EPP earns the "exceeds" rating for this metric because of their annual evaluation system of program reports. The EPP shared that each fall, programs submit reports to the Dean's office outlining how curriculum and key assessments align with national standards. Additionally, faculty review candidate progress through the EPP's key assessments which are mapped to specific standards. During the annual data day, faculty examine assessment data, identify strength and growth areas and develop action plans to ensure the programs remain aligned with national standards while meeting the needs of candidates.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development
EXCEEDS

Coursework clearly and intentionally familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Academic Standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area. Coursework clearly and intentionally provides candidates opportunities to vertically integrate standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area. Specific examples found in the MAT program includes the Unit Plan Template which requires a candidate to align lesson plans to Arkansas K-12 standards, make connections to previous and future learning for K-12 students and provide rationale for decisions to demonstrate that candidates understand the connections. This reflective process allows supervisors to review the narrative information and guide or redirect their candidates, as needed. Another assessment is the Impact on Student Learning Project, which requires candidates to align their lesson plans to AR K-12 standards as part of the process for pre-assessment and post-assessment of K-12 student learning.

Both Coursework focus group participants noted K-12 standards are embedded in every project, and they expressed familiarity with academic standards for content at differing grade levels. Current course lessons were designed around standards and "key takeaways" to know what standards candidates are expected to teach to their students.

Coursework clearly and intentionally provides candidates with opportunities to vertically integrate standards throughout all grade bands within licensure areas. Respondents stated that they were using AR K-12 standards with the various course assignments.

In one course observation, Classroom Assessment (MAT 4321), reviewers noted that teacher candidates identify Arkansas Standards for grades K-12 within their discipline and evaluate how the standards progress for each grade. Students also complete a horizontal alignment for their discipline and chosen grade level to see how standards connect and build throughout a school year.

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric because of their system to evaluate how Arkansas K-12 Academic Standards are incorporated into coursework. All course syllabi go through a review process by the dean each term to be evaluated for the inclusion of AR K-12 standards. The EPP's key assessments also provide system evidence that standards are incorporated, allowing faculty to verify candidates are learning the standards, how to unpack them and how to vertically integrate across grade bands. Finally, the EPP surveys program completers and school partners about the candidate's ability to "align instruction to Arkansas standards" and consistently scores a rating of "adequately prepared."

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher
MEETS

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses

MEETS

Courses are clearly and intentionally sequenced across programs of study to build off previous coursework, providing candidates an opportunity to show proficiency. The Academic Map (AMAP) for each program shows how the EPP structures course completion, including their institution's core required coursework, to support the candidate through the program of study and fieldwork. Data-Driven Instructional Planning (ELSE 4331) provides a description for the "Assessment Planning Project and Analysis" assignment that is designed to prepare candidates for their Impact on Student Learning during their future internship semester. Syllabi also notes prerequisite courses required for current course content. While some courses are natural prerequisites for others Multi-Sensory Approach to Language I and II (ELSE 6348 and ELSE 6349), most courses allow students the flexibility to take them when the course is offered.

Participants in the Coursework focus group all agreed that year one coursework focused on general, or base knowledge, and year two coursework built on the foundational classes, becoming more specialized.

In an observation of Analysis & Practice of Teaching (MAT 5310), the reviewers found that the course is properly sequenced, allowing candidates to unpack standards (AR Teaching Standards), align with pedagogical learning theories, and learn and analyze Bloom's Taxonomy, DOK, and Cognitive Rigor. The course provided a deep dive into the AR Teacher Evaluation System to ensure candidates fully understood expectations for AR teachers. Candidates demonstrated their understanding of the information through a Lesson Plan Project and Mini-Teach.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework

EXCEEDS

Most coursework is clearly aligned with AR Educator competencies and AR Teaching Standards, where appropriate, in a way that develops candidates to meet the knowledge and skills in their required licensure area. Specific examples include the Classroom Assessment (MAT 6311) syllabus which shows the incorporation of the Arkansas Teaching Standards. Advanced Strategies in Elementary Education (MAT 6338) incorporates Arkansas Teaching Standards and includes content language in course assessments.

In the Course Instructor focus group, participants stated that course syllabus notes several threads for the various level AR Educator competencies – standards and checkpoints. Every course created must align topics covered and assessments to standards.

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric by demonstrating a system to evaluate how competencies and teaching standards are incorporated in coursework. The EPP utilizes the DESE matrices to map course content to state expectations. During program reviews and data analysis sessions, faculty review and update the matrices based on curriculum changes. The EPP's exit, completer and employer surveys are aligned with InTASC standards. Survey results are analyzed in faculty committees and during the annual data day to identify strength and growth areas and to develop action plans.

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience

MEETS

Most of the coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned with clinical experiences, where appropriate, through the explicit language used in the syllabi and for key assessment instructions. Specific examples include Positive Classroom Environment for K-6 (ELSE 4309) and special education majors in part of Jr. Block, which requires a field component and assessment, Math and Science for Diverse Learners (ELSE 4301); and Foundations of Reading (ELSE 4311), which also contain field components and assessments. Instructional Strategies for Math/Science, K-6 (ELSE4316), notes three specific field assignments. Behavior Guidance for the Diverse Classroom (ELSE 4302) specifically notes "All field assignments are designed around course content." In addition, the program utilizes the Unit Plan Template and Impact on Student Learning Project to demonstrate candidate knowledge and skills aligned with clinical experiences and provides opportunities for candidates to discuss alignment with course instructors.

Participants in the Coursework focus group shared examples of classroom management strategies that have been implemented (including student-led instruction and gamification to ensure student engagement), and opportunities to practice with differentiating instruction (how to make three different lesson plans for the classroom). Candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment with their course instructors, as evidenced

by examples of the use of learning strategies and curriculum applied in the classroom (UFLY curriculum, Handwriting without Tears, and strategies teaching math and science).

In course Classroom Assessment (MAT 6311) the entire course is building an assessment blueprint to develop and measure student learning aligned with objectives aligned with AR K-12 standards. In addition, the course instructor provides two track options for the assessment blueprint (one for candidates with content areas using dedicated HQIM and one for candidates in other content areas without dedicated HQIM).

Candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment with their course instructor. The assessment blueprint is built across the course, with various components submitted individually, allowing the instructor to provide feedback to candidates. Candidates must also complete assignments, such as the IOSL Pre Assessment Analysis, Differentiation Strategy Assessment plan narrative, and complete a final Impact on Student Learning project which provides a reflection on their understanding of key concepts and their learning throughout the course.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of Arkansas Academic K12 standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy through their degree credentials, teaching certifications, and PreK-12 teaching experience. In addition, the majority of faculty have specific areas of expertise noted and professional development and training listed. The EPP keeps track of faculty scholarships, support and training. Evidence of scholarship and professional development is present in the examples of annual reviews.

Reviewers observed the high quality of course instructors in all three observations. In Classroom Assessment (MAT 6311) the course instructor demonstrated deep content knowledge of effective assessment development processes. Evidence included her use of academic language throughout the course, demonstrating deep understanding of functions and structures of assessment in K12 classrooms, and a focus on using HQIM to create assessments that are rigorous, relevant, and responsive to diverse learners.

In Analysis & Practice of Teaching (MAT 5310), the course instructor demonstrated knowledge of AR HQIM and state standards in the course design by providing opportunities for candidates to sequence learning across the course from beginning to end. The course instructor provided consistent check-ins with candidates for feedback and support of concepts, provided in an asynchronous format. The course instructor has 14 years of experience in the classroom, holds a terminal degree in education, and is a National Board-Certified Teacher.

In Classroom Assessment (MAT 4321) the course instructor presented his Google Classroom which linked to the standards for all disciplines and grade levels. He was knowledgeable in his conversation explaining the course and what it looked like for all disciplines including, K-6, Social Studies, Middle School Math, and Family and Consumer Science.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

EXCEEDS

Course instructors show evidence of strong facilitation of coursework. Participants in the Coursework focus group said they "received criticism and praise in feedback from instructors, never just a 'good job' but specific, helpful feedback on submissions." Another participant described the course instructors as "responsive, available instructors". A third shared their coursework is well-organized and clear. Detailed rubrics for assessment are used, the candidate knows what they are expected to do and course instructors are flexible on submissions and allow resubmissions.

In Classroom Assessment (MAT 6311), the course instructor provided numerous instructional videos for introducing concepts, completing assignments, and also had some pre-set optional Zoom Meetings for additional support. The course was well organized and provided learning goals for each module, resources (readings/videos), and was intentionally aligned to relevant standards to help candidates make connections to evidence-based practice.

In Analysis & Practice of Teaching (MAT 5310), the course instructor demonstrated knowledge of AR HQIM and state standards in the course design by providing opportunities for candidates to sequence learning across the course from beginning to end. The course instructor provides consistent check-ins with candidates for feedback and support of concepts provided in an asynchronous format.

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric due to their in-depth annual evaluation of course instructor effectiveness. The faculty evaluations include a one-on-one meeting with the department chair where they discuss their performance and progress towards goals, and goals are established for the next year. The Evaluation of Supervisors AY23-24 evidence provides a narrative of how the data were evaluated and specific changes made in "supervisor training, communication protocols, and support structures". Another comprehensive evidence piece is the Completer Survey AY23-24 administered to Traditional and MAT completers, with prompts aligned to InTASC Standards. This data can be disaggregated and evaluated by content area as well. The Employer Survey AY23-24 collects employer perception of candidate preparation aligned to InTASC Standards, which in part is a reflection on the effectiveness of course instructors. Survey results are provided in aggregate to the EPP and in content area licensure. Evidence packages for the surveys and evaluations indicate that the data are reviewed and provided to the program coordinators. The "Student Work and Feedback" links provide evidence that most candidates receive specific, actionable feedback, in some combination of criterion-specific, overall, or both that recognizes achievement and areas for future improvement.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

EXCEEDS

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

EXCEEDS

The sequence of clinical experiences builds off previous experiences and provides opportunities for learning and development. MAT candidates typically work as the teacher of record, so they are already in classrooms full time. However, they have opportunities in their coursework to conduct case studies and analyze classroom management scenarios from practicing teachers. Courses require candidates to participate in "early field experiences" that include observations, reading to students, tutoring and working with small groups.

One participant in the Clinical Experience focus group said, "UCA prepared me well with applicable learning, sequence and scaffolding, and seeking out collaborative experiences, as well as the exposure to HQIM." Clinical Supervisor focus group participants acknowledged the challenges that come with a MAT program and being able to provide a sequence that builds upon experiences. However, they were able to provide examples of how they are intentionally building their program. One participant shared that MAT candidates begin field experiences early with their first two courses. They assign an interview where each candidate reaches out to three to five teachers to investigate topics of interest such as behavior management. One clinical supervisor said, "We try to balance the situation and the need to put candidates into schools as much as possible; all candidates are required to spend actual time in building within their first six course hours if they are not already working in a school building."

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric as evidenced by their evaluation system to continually improve the sequence of clinical experiences. Meeting minutes from the monthly ILPC Committee meeting highlight discussion around the sequence of clinical experiences. In November 2024, the committee reviewed the scope and sequence maps for all clinical experiences across every program.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

EXCEEDS

Candidates are provided with a variety of clinical experiences that provide opportunities to work with students with varied learning needs. As teachers of record, most MAT candidates work in schools that have varying types of students with diverse learning needs. In addition to their work experiences, throughout their coursework, they are

required to complete specific assignments to support the needs of students in their classrooms. For example, in Contemporary Methods (MAT 5332), candidates implement interventions for specific student challenges.

In the Clinical Experience focus group, three of the four participants provided an example of their clinical experiences and the different opportunities they had in working with students with varied learning needs. They said that even though they are teachers of record, they had observations or various opportunities to work in other areas outside of their grade level or licensure area as part of their coursework requirements. One participant shared they worked with a child who was falling behind and on an IEP. The candidate was tasked with developing lesson plans and modifying lessons.

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric as evidenced by their evaluation system to continually improve the sequence of clinical experiences. In November 2024, the ILPC Committee reviewed the scope and sequence maps for all clinical experiences across every program, paying careful attention to where field experiences would take place. This review allowed for informed adjustments to ensure candidates have a variety of field experiences and the opportunity to work with students of varied learning needs.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship MEETS

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers EXCEEDS

Most experienced mentor teachers demonstrate they have the coaching skills to support candidate development. In the "Mentor Teacher Tracker" 38 out of 46 (82%) mentor teachers reported having rubric training and all have at least three years of experience and effective or highly effective summative rating. On average, candidates rated their mentor teachers highly, with an average score of 2.8 (out of 3) satisfaction with their mentor on a mentor teacher feedback survey.

Experienced mentor teachers participate in training at the beginning of the semester and are provided with a comprehensive handbook to support them throughout the semester. They utilize a POP cycle and the Aspiring Teacher Rubric (ATR) to provide feedback to candidates.

In the Clinical Experience focus group, participants had positive experiences with their mentor teachers and provided multiple examples of support they receive. One participant said, "My mentor provides great feedback, and I value their vast experience in a variety of classrooms and learning environments". Another participant said, "My mentor gives the best feedback to help me improve especially on pacing and checks for understanding." All participants said they meet with their mentor teacher daily and agreed their mentor supported them effectively.

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric due to their evaluation and tracking systems of mentor teachers. The EPP evaluates mentor teacher effectiveness each semester through a survey given to candidates and university supervisors. These evaluation data are tracked in a spreadsheet that includes mentor teacher qualifications and recent trainings. Data is reviewed annually by the Director of Candidates Services, the Assessment Director, and relevant program coordinators and chairs to determine if mentors need additional supports or if certain mentors should not be utilized in future semesters.

Note: By 2026-2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. [Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual](#)

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers MEETS

A process is in place to select experienced mentor teachers. According to the MOU example shared by the EPP, there is a set of criteria that mentor teachers must meet that is aligned with guidance from DESE. The EPP provided a database of "Mentor Teacher Data" confirming mentor teacher qualification. This document also serves as a tracker for performance. The EPP evaluates mentor teacher effectiveness each semester through candidate and clinical supervisor feedback.

In the School Partnership focus group, participants explained that selection of mentors is completed by the district and provided to the EPP based on subject and grade level need. The MOU outlines the process for the Director of Clinical Experiences working with the partner school to identify experienced mentor teachers for candidates.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors
MEETS

Most program clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. On a 3-point scale, with 3 being above average, candidates rated their clinical supervisors 2.76 for “provided immediate feedback” and a rating of 2.84 for “shows respect.”

In the Clinical Experience focus group, all candidates spoke positively about their clinical supervisor, stating they are willing to help, provide feedback, and are accessible. One candidate said, “[My] Mentor Teacher is also an academic administrator, they provide great feedback and have a vast experience in all kinds of classrooms. My experienced mentor has been so helpful.” Participants in the Experienced Mentor Teacher focus group could also provide examples of how clinical supervisors support candidates. One participant said, “The supervisor I’m working with is very knowledgeable. She’s a retired teacher and still substitutes, so she still has current knowledge. She drops by every other week to check in with both of us, but she checks in individually as well.”

Review teams in both coaching observations, noted strong instructional practices and coaching. In both observations, reviewers said the clinical supervisor created a positive space for discussion and asked multiple times if the teacher candidate had any questions. In one observation, the clinical supervisor offered suggestions and resources when working with students with IEPs. In the other observation, the clinical supervisor met with the candidate before the lesson to review best practices and answer questions.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates
EXCEEDS

Candidates consistently receive high-quality feedback. Supervisors are required to conduct three formal observations using the POP cycle throughout a candidate’s internship experience. Experienced mentor teachers conduct informal and formal observations and provide regular feedback. All feedback is linked to the Aspiring TESS rubric. Feedback is written and oral, and clinical supervisors are expected to provide feedback within one week of assignments being submitted. Interns receive feedback on their lesson plan, teaching and lesson reflection as part of the POP cycle.

All participants in the Clinical Experience focus group, agreed they receive high quality feedback and feel supported by their clinical supervisor. Participants in the Clinical Supervisor focus group shared that to provide consistency across all programs, “we use shared planning documents, observation documentation, reflection documents, and shared rubrics (Aspiring TESS). We use a Lesson Analysis document that challenges students to connect lesson plans to student achievement.”

In both observed coaching sessions, the clinical supervisor facilitated the conversation during the post-observation meeting using cognitive coaching strategies including active listening, open-ended questioning and reflective feedback.

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric due to their system for monitoring candidate feedback. Clinical supervisors submit feedback through the EPP’s system, Chalk & Wire, which is monitored monthly by the Director of Assessment to confirm all candidates are receiving regular feedback within the expected timeline. At mid-semester, experienced mentor teachers complete a disposition evaluation on their candidate with rating options based on the UCA COE Disposition Rubric and Aspiring TESS Components.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates
MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools
EXCEEDS

Collaborative processes are in place with most districts to co-construct the clinical internship for candidates. UCA partners with a variety of schools across Arkansas to support teacher candidates with field experiences and

internships. UCA utilizes MOUs to establish expectations for partnerships. These agreements are reviewed and renewed annually. One specific example of a strong partnership is with East End School District where Elementary and special education candidates engage in literacy assessment and intervention practices, and middle and secondary candidates work with struggling readers.

Clinical supervisors also demonstrate a strong collaborative effort with experienced mentor teachers. They work together to rate the summative aspiring TESS evaluation and check in regularly on the progress of candidates. Clinical Supervisor focus group participants indicated there are some formal structures in place to collaborate with experienced mentor teachers, including a virtual meeting that includes candidates at the beginning of the semester. Experienced mentor teachers agree, saying there is collaboration between the EPP and the school to create a strong clinical internship to develop teacher candidates. While one EMT noted geography as a barrier to on-site collaboration, the majority mentioned that proximity afforded the clinical supervisor to be onsite more often.

UCA earns the exceeds rating for this metric as evidenced by their continuous improvement to ensure partnerships are mutually beneficial. UCA utilizes advisory boards and working groups to collaborate with partner schools. Program-specific advisory boards meet annually, and the Executive Advisory Board meets twice yearly to co-construct EPP practices. These groups analyze program data, review key assessments and provide actionable feedback. One example is the TESS Ad Hoc Working Group who met to determine the transition to utilizing the ATR. The EPP is currently involving partner schools in discussions about the year-long residency requirements. Another example shared in the School Partnership focus group was that UCA reviewed data and implemented trauma informed practices with the co-op, collaborating on faculty and student training. All seven school partners agreed that UCA is receptive to feedback.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

UCA demonstrates a strong commitment to the development and support of their clinical supervisors. UCA evaluates all faculty annually. This evaluation includes grade distributions, annual goals, summary of teaching efforts and accomplishments. In addition to annual evaluations conducted by UCA, the EPP also collects feedback from candidates and mentor teachers at the end of each term. Feedback is provided directly to the clinical supervisor to further support their growth. In addition to evaluations, clinical supervisors are required to complete professional development. Professional development is offered by UCA and includes topics such as HQIM, Science of Reading, coaching and data analysis. UCA's Director of Assessment provides dedicated training for new faculty and requires training for all supervisors each term. UCA provided agendas from calibration meetings that show evidence of supervisor training, including case studies and discussion about the POP Cycle, Aspiring TESS and giving feedback to candidates.

Clinical supervisors affirmed the EPP's commitment to their development in the focus group. Participants shared the College and Departments offer frequent opportunities for professional development, including attending conferences, university sponsored instructional improvement opportunities, state meetings, and faculty meetings. One participant said, "we are continually challenged and share when we think something should be changed; we join cohorts to make changes to what we all use, and we are invested."

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

EXCEEDS

Most candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. All programs have GPA data above 3.0 for admissions and graduates and data shows that all program completer's GPA increased.

The EPP tracks data in an Airtable database updated to track progress through program gates. Data is input from multiple people including the program coordinator, course instructor, intern supervisor, and the mentor teacher who complete surveys that connect to the Airtable spreadsheet

The EPP submitted evidence to earn the exceeds rating for this metric. The EPP monitors candidate progress from admission to program completion to ensure readiness for certification and effective teaching. Data from the “Gates System” informs the EPPs quality assurance processes by collecting evaluations from multiple sources and measures at key progressions point. Program coordinators and faculty analyze program milestone data to identify areas for improvement, leading to recent changes such as adopting Airtable for tracking, revising disposition assessments, and enhancing candidate support structures.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

MEETS

Candidates are consistently provided with an individualized support plan if their coursework requirements are off track, and they take an active role in creating the plan and monitoring progress. The EPP provided three examples of individualized support plans based on data from Airtable tracking system. The plans include sections that explain the areas of concern, links to the dispositions or rubric, suggestions for courses of action with candidate input, follow up meeting notes, and progress tracking.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

MEETS

Programs have a set of clear and appropriate goals and milestones for candidates’ clinical internship. The EPP includes a well-structured clinical internship program with clear goals, expectations, and milestones. There are multiple formal observations, detailed lesson planning, comprehensive unit planning, and impact on student learning assessments. The EPP uses a detailed documentation system to track candidate progress through platforms like Blackboard and Chalk & Wire. The MAT Internship Handbook outlines week-by-week expectations to keep candidates on track. Eighty six percent of graduates become licensed.

In the Clinical Experience focus group, participants shared they were given a rubric and handbook that outlined the milestones of the program. There is a big emphasis on being a proficient teacher. Clinical Supervisors confirmed this in their focus group saying, “from the start we introduce what effective teaching looks like through Aspiring TESS and Danielson’s framework. Every class (pedagogy) is aligned to the components, so candidates add to their understanding of what it means/looks like to be an effective teacher through their program, until they put it all together through the lesson observations experiences in the internships.

The EPP provided evidence to demonstrate continuous improvements to track and evaluate the effectiveness of the goals and milestones. Each year, every program submits an annual review to look at program growth. They look at unit plans and data to determine where they are getting stronger and where they need to analyze and make changes based on review of material each year, however, reviewers did not observe evidence highlighting changes the EPP has made based on findings.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

EXCEEDS

There is adequate evidence candidates have the capacity to impact student growth. UCA assigns an “Impact on Student Learning” project that candidates use to examine their effect on students’ learning based on the unit plan they submit and two assessment points from the students. Candidates analyze and reflect on data and are responsible for reteaching and adjusting based on outcomes of data.

Participants in the Clinical Internship focus group shared examples of how they impact student growth. They mentioned they analyze test scores and compare assessment data and consider if students are meeting lesson objectives. Participants also witnessed growth through the rapport and relationships they built with students. Clinical Supervisors provided examples of impact on student growth. One focus group participant said, “we have candidates

teach and reteach; analyze student data; and dig into specific standard or standards and share with them that is what should be happening in every lesson; looking at data and using it to teach our students.”

The EPP earns the exceeds rating for this metric as evidenced by their continuous evaluation of the “Impact of Student Learning” assessment. The assessment was developed in 2014 with input from various stakeholders. The assessment was piloted in 2014-15 and adjusted based on data and feedback. In 2019, the rubric was updated with K-12 partner input, and through continued advisory boards, the assessment continues to be evaluated. Data from the assessment show steady gains across all criteria since 2019-20 and more consistent performance with decreasing standard deviations. The EPP shared that when challenges arise, such as lower scores in the “Reflection on Unit and Student Learning”, the EPP addresses them by forming faculty working groups to ensure consistency and to improve support materials.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Most candidates receive a score of effective on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. The data show consistently strong performance across three years (2001-2024), with mean scores between 2.84-3.07 across all domains.

Note: By 2024-25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

MEETS

All candidates with varied needs are provided with the support they need if their clinical internship is offtrack. The EPP uses data from the ATR to assess if and in what areas candidates need support in their clinical internship. Responses to those who need support are systematic and differentiated ensuring appropriate support for all candidates. The candidate’s supervisor and mentor teacher provide documentation and recommendations for improvement. Candidate progress is also evaluated using midterm disposition evaluations completed by mentor teachers.

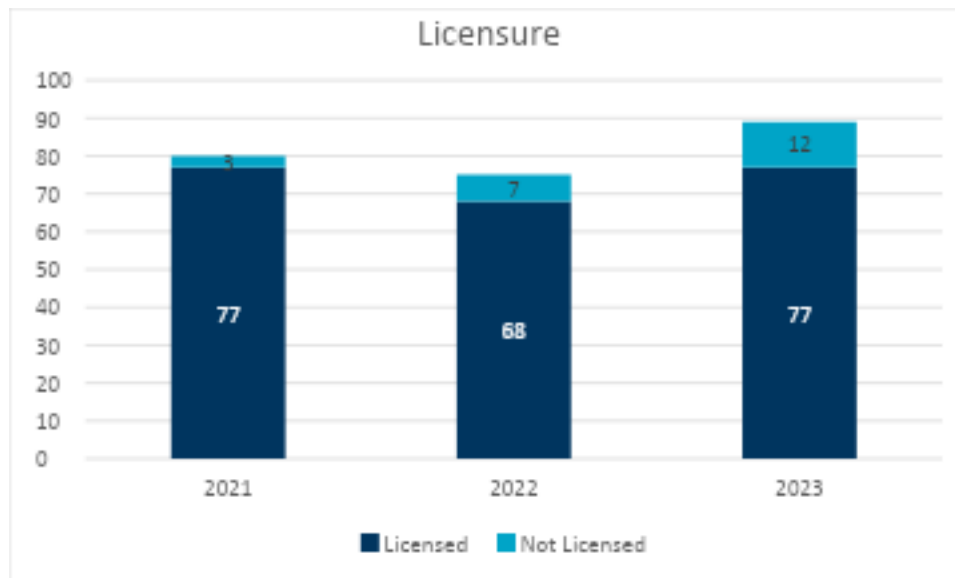
High performing candidates from undergraduate and graduate programs are recognized each year as “Student of the Year” or “Graduate Student of the Year.” Students are honored at a pinning ceremony and highlighted as evidenced in the monthly newsletter submitted as evidence.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
EXCEEDS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
EXCEEDS	EXCEEDS	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
UCA's alternative route program meets or exceeds nearly all of the State's targets for EPPs to support Arkansas's workforce needs, including completers who become licensed, work in Arkansas public schools and districts (including priority districts and subjects), and stay in the classroom for multiple years. Recommendations include: Continue to review EPP Completer Supervisor Survey and EPP Completer Survey results to identify specific domains and components for which both supervisors and candidates do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3a and 3.3b</i>)		

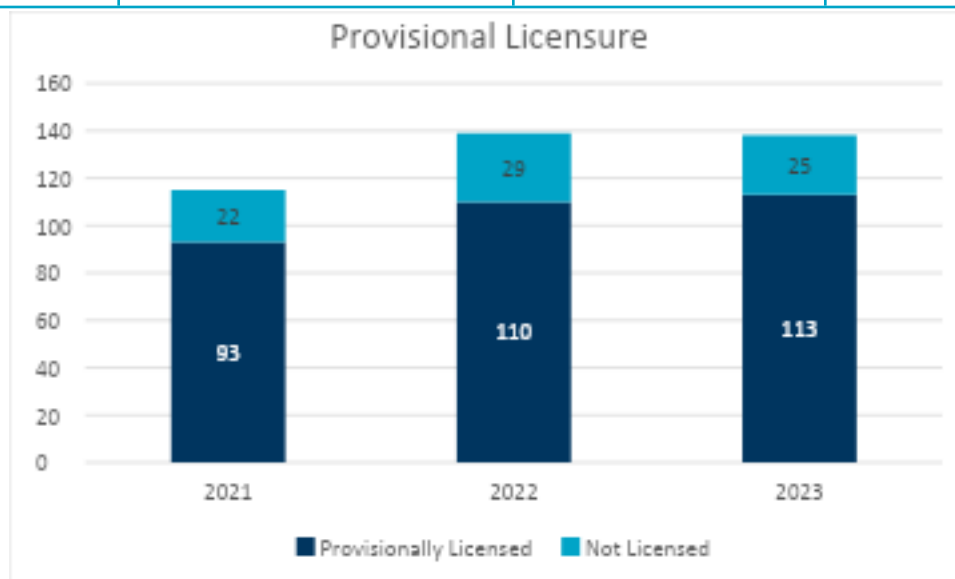
INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license within one year of completion	80%	91%	EXCEEDS



Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	73%	74.5%	EXCEEDS



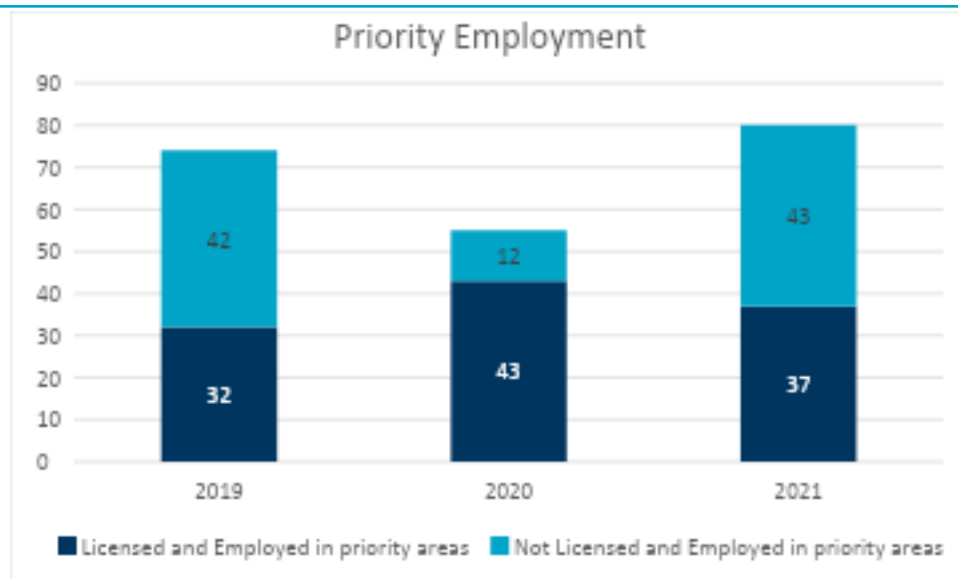
Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
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Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	66%	n/a	n/a

INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level												
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	68%	75.6%	EXCEEDS												
Employment <table><thead><tr><th>Year</th><th>Licensed and Employed</th><th>Not Licensed and Employed</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>2019</td><td>51</td><td>23</td></tr><tr><td>2020</td><td>48</td><td>7</td></tr><tr><td>2021</td><td>59</td><td>21</td></tr></tbody></table>				Year	Licensed and Employed	Not Licensed and Employed	2019	51	23	2020	48	7	2021	59	21
Year	Licensed and Employed	Not Licensed and Employed													
2019	51	23													
2020	48	7													
2021	59	21													
Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level												
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	39%	53.6%	EXCEEDS												



*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

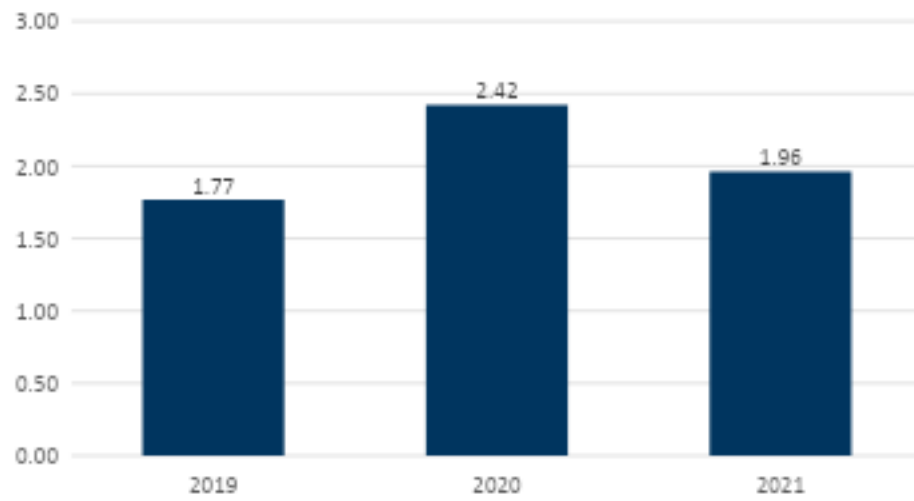
Current subject shortage areas for employment: Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.8	2.01	EXCEEDS

Average Experience 3 years After Completion



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	78%	76.1%	MEETS
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	79%	81.4%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	53%	EXCEEDS

